What Would Make Us Pick This Up Again?

Fifteen changes to notice and write down while Mom is managing on her own, with no interpreting.

Mom is doing well, and you'd like to keep an eye on things without hovering. This guide names fifteen things worth noticing over the coming months and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. Nothing on this list is a sign that something is wrong, and nothing on it says anything about Medicaid. What a change means for Mom's health is a question for her doctor; what it means for your family's plan is a question for your Medicaid planner. The everyday activities follow the Administration for Community Living's lists, and a few household details follow AARP's description of what a care manager notices on a home visit. The wording about what to write down is ours.

Day to day

1 Personal care [1]

NOTICE Bathing, dressing, getting up from a chair: anything Mom used to do without thinking that now takes longer, needs a hand, or gets skipped.

WRITE DOWN What changed and roughly when. Leave out what you think it means.

2 Running the house [1]

NOTICE Meals, shopping, housework, the telephone, her pills: who does each one now, and whether that has shifted.

WRITE DOWN Any task that has moved from Mom to someone else, and to whom.

3 The mail and the bills [1] [2]

NOTICE Unopened mail collecting on the counter, a bill paid twice or not at all, a statement she'd normally have filed.

WRITE DOWN What you saw, with the date.

4 Getting around [2]

NOTICE A fall or a near-fall, a hand on the furniture as she walks, stairs or rooms she has stopped using.

WRITE DOWN Date, place, and what she was doing. Don't decide why.

Health and memory

5 A hospital stay

NOTICE Any stay or emergency visit, however short, and what Mom was told when she left.

WRITE DOWN The dates, the place, and where the papers she came home with are kept.

6 A new diagnosis

NOTICE A condition newly named by a doctor, or a change in one she already has.

WRITE DOWN The doctor's words, the date, and who was in the room. What it means for her care is the doctor's to say.

7 Memory [2]

NOTICE A question repeated, an appointment missed, a familiar drive that gave her trouble.

WRITE DOWN What happened and how often, not what it means.

8 A move, or talk of one

NOTICE A move to a relative's home, to assisted living or to a care facility, or serious talk of one.

WRITE DOWN What is being considered, who raised it, and any dates mentioned.

The people helping

9 Who does what [3]

NOTICE The help that has grown up around Mom: a neighbor who brings in the trash cans, your brother driving her to appointments, you doing her taxes.

WRITE DOWN Each person, what they do, and about how often. Update it when it changes.

10 A family caregiver needing more support [3]

NOTICE Whether the person doing the most is doing more than a season ago: more hours, more driving, time taken off work.

WRITE DOWN What has been added, in that person's own words.

11 What Mom says she wants

NOTICE Remarks about where she'd want to live, who she'd want helping, and what she wouldn't want.

WRITE DOWN Her words, with the date, each time the subject comes up.

Money and paper

12 What help is costing [4]

NOTICE Any new regular expense for help, such as a cleaner, rides, an aide or a medical alert button, and whether the monthly total is growing.

WRITE DOWN Each expense, when it started, and what it comes to in a month. Keep the receipts.

13 Changes to accounts, property or insurance

NOTICE An account opened or closed, a gift, a change to the name on the house, a policy bought, lapsed or cancelled, whether by Mom or by someone helping her.

WRITE DOWN What changed, the date, and where the paperwork is. Don't decide what it means; note it and mention it to your Medicaid planner.

14 Letters from an agency or an insurer

NOTICE Anything from Medicare, Social Security, a pension, an insurance company or a state agency.

WRITE DOWN The date on it, who sent it, and where you put it. Don't interpret it.

15 Her legal documents [5] [6]

NOTICE Whether her will, and any power of attorney or health care documents she has signed, can be found, and whether anything has changed for the people named in them.

WRITE DOWN Which documents exist, the date on each, where each is kept, and who has a copy.

When to bring your notes to someone

There is no score here, and no number of changes that means anything by itself. If something on this list has changed and you find yourself wondering whether it matters, that is the moment to ask. Health and safety questions go to Mom's doctor, and anything sudden with her health is a call to the doctor, not a note for later. Questions about what a change means for the plan go to your Medicaid planner, questions about her documents to an elder law attorney, and questions about a policy to a licensed insurance professional. The Family Caregiver Alliance's general advice is for a family to meet again when the caregiving situation changes.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any change means, how serious it is, whether it's time to act, or anything about eligibility. It doesn't choose your family's list of events either: which ones would reopen the plan is worked out with your Medicaid planner. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to notice, and you've started writing it down. The planning interview asks about your family's situation as it stands today and gives you a free planning report you can keep with your notes and bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. AARP, Geriatric Care Managers Advocate for Older Adults — and Their Caregivers
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
4. AARP, A Legal Checklist for Family Caregivers
5. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Legal Steps for Medical Well-being
6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Considering a financial caregiver? Know your options